

DESCRIPTIVE WRITING

Painting a picture with words



1 What is it?

Descriptive Writing

Descriptive writing uses **vivid, precise detail** to help the reader picture a person, place or thing clearly — appealing to the senses rather than just stating facts.

precise detail + the five senses = a vivid picture

2 See it in action

A plain sentence

The beach was nice. Flat and forgettable — the reader sees nothing.

A descriptive sentence

Golden sand stretched for miles, warm beneath bare feet. The reader can picture it.

Describing a person

Her weathered hands trembled slightly as she turned the yellowed pages.

Describing a mood

The classroom felt cold and clinical, all hard edges and silence.



Mfalme says...

Pick **one small, specific detail** rather than describing everything — a single cracked windowpane says more than "the house was old and broken."

FUN FACT

Exam mark schemes specifically reward "precise, ambitious vocabulary" over quantity — one perfectly chosen word (like "trudged" instead of "walked") often scores higher than three vague ones.

3 Why writers use it

Descriptive Writing helps writers: immerse the reader in a scene, create atmosphere and mood without stating it directly, and make writing memorable through specific, carefully chosen detail rather than vague generalisation.

The strongest descriptive writing is selective — it doesn't describe everything, just the two or three details that do the most work in creating a picture or feeling.

4 Don't mix it up!

Descriptive Writing

- Focuses on **painting a picture**
- Often slows the pace down
- Answers: what does it look/feel like?

Narrative Writing

- Focuses on **telling a story**
- Driven by events and plot
- Answers: what happens next?



Watch out!

Don't just list adjectives ("the big, scary, dark, old house") — a few precise, well-chosen details almost always beat a long pile of generic ones.



Look here!

Ask yourself which **sense** you haven't used yet — sight is easy, but smell, sound and touch often create the strongest, most original descriptions.

5 Quick recap

Uses vivid, precise detail

Appeals to the five senses

Creates a clear picture or mood



You got this!

Try describing your bedroom in exactly three sentences, using a different sense in each one — notice how much more vivid it feels than a plain list of objects.